



Munwar Shariff,
co-founder and chief technology
officer at CIGNEX Datamatics

“Our motivation for taking up open source as a business model stems from the business reality that there are more than 200,000 open

source software options for an organisation to choose from, but only the right partner can help it minimise the risk and reduce adoption time, while ensuring performance, scalability, high availability, quality and security; so that’s where we fit in.”

he has co-authored five technical books—Plone Live, Implementing Alfresco, Alfresco 3 WCM, Alfresco 3 ECM and Alfresco 4 ECM Implementation.

“With over 13 years of experience and 400+ open source solutions, we have gained a vast experience in enabling enterprise clients to address their technology challenges and business needs through our tailor-made open source solutions (OSS). Our solutions enable them to make smart architecture-related decisions through a feasibility study, accelerate time-to-market through proven open source based product frameworks; and enable coexistence with proprietary solutions by the integration of applications and more. We also reduce the enterprise’s risk in dealing with open source software through our open source adoption model (OSAM), best practices, project governance, and knowledge transfer,” explains Shariff.

The profitability mantra

It’s not often that companies figure out how to use open source to reinforce their businesses but CIGNEX Datamatics was quick to realise its potential.

The benchmark for a successful open source enterprise solutions player lies in how efficiently it

is able to leverage its partnerships with leading open source technology platforms, believes Shariff. “We have forged strategic partnerships with commercial open source technology leaders for portals (Liferay Platinum partner), content management (Global Alfresco Platinum Partner), Big Data (MongoDB Advanced Partner, Cloudera Hadoop Partner) and e-commerce (Magento Silver Partner). In Liferay, we have implemented over 200 enterprise solutions across all verticals, are a certified Liferay training partner, authored seven books and contributed over 4000 posts in various blogs, forums, wikis, etc. Likewise, we have authored five books on Alfresco and delivered over 80 implementations across various industries, worldwide,” says Shariff.

The courage to go open

Unless you firmly believe in the potential of FOSS, you will think twice about adopting open source as a viable business model. So what motivated CIGNEX Datamatics to go open? “Demand for open source has gained considerable momentum among enterprises in recent years, not only due to its cost benefits but also the greater freedom of choice it offers, complete visibility into all aspects of an application, and consistent improvements in the user experience. Our motivation for taking up open source as a business model stems from the business reality that there are more than 200,000 open source software options for an organisation to choose from, but only the right partner can help it minimise the risk and reduce adoption time, while ensuring performance, scalability, high availability, quality and security; so that’s where we fit in,” says Shariff.

The business case for open source

The company’s clients include leading names among Fortune 500 enterprises as well as government agencies.

So are most of CIGNEX Datamatics’ customers adopting open source solutions along with proprietary applications or are they replacing them completely? And how does it work—does CIGNEX approach a firm and convince it to try open source solutions or is it the other way round? “It’s really a mixed bag. We have adequate cases where we really had to evangelise the benefits of open source solutions. But many times, clients were already aware of its benefits and approached us directly as we have a sizeable number of implementations and reference case studies in developing customised solutions using Liferay, Alfresco, Drupal, Magento, and more. In most cases, we see a co-existence between proprietary solutions and our open source solutions because of the immense interoperability between the two,” explains Shariff.